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PSYC100

The conformity effect

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: The conformity effect.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've learned, what comes next, and how you learn best.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Imagine you’re in a team meeting at work. The group is asked a simple question:

Which chart matches the one on the screen? You’re sure the correct answer is B.

One by one, everyone before you confidently says C.

Now it’s your turn to answer… and all eyes are on you. 👀

What do you think you’d do in that moment?

Stick with B (what you really think)
Go along with C (what everyone else said)

You don’t have to explain yet—just tell me which way you feel you’d lean.

from past expericne id stick with b i dont mind being different

Love that confidence, Ron 👏 That “I don’t mind being different” attitude actually protects you from certain social pressures.

I just pulled up a short video of Asch’s conformity experiment for you. It shows a situation very much like the meeting example, but in a lab.

👉 Watch the video above, then tell me in one short line:

What surprised you the most about how people behaved?

the most surprising thing t me is only 5pct ttally fell in ith the majority all the time. i honestly expect the go along with the herd mentality to be at least 30pct

That reaction is sharp, and it puts you in the right mindset for this lesson 🔍

Quick reality check on the numbers, though: in Asch’s original study, the famous summary is usually:

About 75% of people conformed at least once,

and the average person conformed on ~1/3 of the critical trials.

So:

Very few people never went along.
Very few people always went along.
Most people were in the messy middle: sometimes independent, sometimes "herd."
Let's zoom in on one key idea now: conformity vs. obedience (since you've seen obedience before).

Simple version:

Conformity = changing your answer/behavior to match peers (people at your level).

Obedience = following orders from an authority (boss, officer, doctor, etc.).

If a whole team of coworkers says the wrong answer and you feel pressure to match them, that's conformity, not obedience—no one is commanding you.

Does that difference (peers vs. authority) feel clear so far, or is there any part of conformity vs. obedience that still blurs together for you?

It's clear now

Nice 👌 that's an important foundation.

Next piece: why people in Asch's study went along with the wrong group answer.

In many of those trials, people knew the line was wrong, but still said it anyway. One big reason is:

Normative influence = changing your answer or behavior so others will accept you or at least not reject you.

It's less about "maybe they're right" and more about "I don't want to look weird / difficult / stupid."

Quick everyday example:

You're not hungry, but everyone at work is ordering food together. You order something anyway just so you're not the only one with nothing. That's normative influence.

Does that idea of "going along to fit in or avoid standing out" make sense so far?

Yes, that makes sense

What do you think? 👇

Which of these is the best example of normative influence?

A.

You copy the group’s answer because you think they’re probably seeing something you missed and might be right.

B.

You copy the group’s answer because you don’t want to be the only one who disagrees and risk looking difficult.

C.

You change your answer after the teacher firmly tells you that you are wrong and must choose another option.

b

Nice, sticking with B there fits what you said about not minding being different 🤝

Now let’s add the other big reason people conform.

Before I name it, here’s the idea:

Sometimes we go along with the group not to fit in, but because we think,

“Maybe they know something I don’t. Maybe I’m wrong.”

For example:

You’re in a new city choosing a place to eat.
One restaurant is empty, the one next door has a long line.
You pick the one with the line, thinking, “That one’s probably better.”

That’s not about fear of rejection; it’s using the group as a source of information.

Psychology calls this informational influence:

Informational influence = looking to others as a guide to what’s correct, especially when you’re uncertain.

Quick check, in your own words:

When you follow the crowd because you think they’re probably right, does that feel different from following them just to fit in?

yes

Perfect ✸

So to lock it in:

Normative influence = “I go along so they’ll like me / not reject me.”
Informational influence = “I go along because I think they’re right and I might be wrong.”
Let’s make this concrete with you.

Imagine this situation:

You join a new hiking group. Everyone says the trail on the left is the correct one back to the parking lot.

You thought it was the right, but you're not totally sure.

You decide to follow them on the left.

In that moment, which feels more true for you:

"They've hiked here before, they probably know better"
"I don't want to be the odd one out going alone to the right"

Answer in your own words (no need to name the term yet) — what would be going through your head?

theyve hiked here before so id follow them

Nice—that's a classic informational influence moment 👍

Your thought is basically: "They probably have better information than I do."

So in that hiking example:

Your motive = to be accurate (find the right trail)
Not mainly to fit in or avoid looking weird

That's informational influence in action.

Want to try a quick 1-question check where you pick whether a situation is normative or informational?

Sure, let's do it!

What do you think fits best in that situation? 👇

You're out with friends. You don't really like beer, but everyone orders one and laughs about "beer being the only real choice." You order a beer too, even though you'd rather have something else. What's the main influence here?

A.

Normative influence (to fit in / avoid standing out)

B.

Informational influence (they probably know what tastes best)

a

Nice work picking A 👀

You're getting the feel for the difference between:

Normative = fit in / avoid standing out
Informational = they're probably right / know more
Next, I want to connect this back to Asch's line experiment you watched.

In that study, most people later said something like:

"I knew the group answer was wrong, but I didn't want to look stupid or stand out."

Step by step:

Their private belief = "The correct line is B."
Their public answer = "C" (to match the group).
Motive = avoid embarrassment / rejection → normative influence.

So even when their eyes told them one thing, social pressure pulled them the other way.

Does that pattern—privately think one thing, publicly say another to fit in—feel clear?

yes its clear

Great 👍

Now let's zoom in on why Asch's study is such a big deal in psychology.

The key takeaway:

Even in a simple, obvious task (matching line lengths),

and with no real rewards or punishments,

many people still conformed to the wrong group answer.

So this shows:

You don't need a boss, threat, or bribe.
Just a unanimous group giving the same wrong answer can be enough to pull people away from what they see with their own eyes.

Psychologists use this to explain why people conform to group pressure:

To avoid standing out (normative influence),
Sometimes because they doubt themselves when everyone disagrees (informational influence).
Before we dig into what makes conformity stronger or weaker (group size, having an ally, etc.), I want to check your sense of this:

If you had to choose one main reason people in Asch's study went along with the wrong answer, would you say it was more:

Wanting to fit in / not look weird
or
Believing the group must be seeing it correctly?

Answer in your own words; don't worry about using the exact terms.

wanting to fit in

Exactly 🎯

In Asch's experiment, the main driver was people wanting to fit in and avoid looking odd or foolish in front of the group — that's normative influence in action.

Now let's go one layer deeper and make this more realistic.

Here’s a quick scenario:

You’re in a meeting. The boss isn’t pushing any answer; it’s just a team discussion. Everyone except you agrees on a plan you secretly think is bad. You feel that tug to just nod along.

In that moment, for you personally, which would be the stronger pull, do you think:

avoiding conflict / not wanting to slow the group down
or
worrying they might know something you’re missing?

Answer in your own words, and then we’ll tie it to how situations change conformity (group size, having one ally, public vs private answers).

id still go with my different answer but interenally be worried they knew something i didndt

That’s a really insightful mix you described, Ron:

Outwardly: you’d still give your different answer 👊
Inwardly: you’d be thinking, “Hmm, maybe they know something I don’t.”

That inner doubt is very much like informational influence (questioning your own view), even though you’re resisting normative pressure (you’re not just going along to fit in).

Next step I’d like to walk through with you:

how the situation changes conformity — things like:

how big the group is
whether even one person agrees with you
whether answers are public or anonymous

Each of these changed behavior in Asch’s studies.

Want to look first at group size or at the power of having one ally who agrees with you?

ok

Got it 👍 let’s start with group size.

Simple idea:

Up to a point, the more people all giving the same wrong answer,

the more pressure you feel to go along.

In Asch’s study:

With 1 other person giving the wrong answer → not much conformity
With 3 people all agreeing on the wrong answer → conformity jumped a lot
Adding more beyond 3 didn’t increase it as much (it kind of leveled off)

So going from 1 → 3 wrong answers matters more than from 3 → 7.

If you were in a room where:

Only 1 coworker disagrees with you
versus
3 coworkers all confidently disagree with you

Which situation would make you feel more pressure to question yourself?

the 3 people

Same here — three confident people against you is a very different feeling than just one 😅

That’s exactly what Asch found:

As the group size increased (up to about 3), conformity increased.
After that, adding more people didn’t change things much.

So: bigger agreeing group → stronger pressure (up to a point).

Next, I want to show you something powerful: how having just one ally (one other person who agrees with you) changes everything.

Ready to look at that?

Yes, let's do it

Awesome ✸

Quick, simple idea about allies:

In Asch’s experiment, when just one other person in the group also gave the correct answer,

conformity dropped sharply.

So:

Standing alone against a unanimous group = high pressure to conform
Standing with one ally, even if everyone else disagrees = pressure drops a lot

It’s like the difference between:

“It’s me vs. everyone”
“It’s us vs. them”
Imagine you’re in that line-judgment task:

Condition 1: Everyone else says C, you think B. You’re alone.
Condition 2: Most say C, but one other person also says B with you.

In your gut, how big a difference would that make?

Would having that one ally make it a little easier to hold your ground, or a lot easier?

A lot easier

Same here. That one voice on your side changes the whole feel of the room 💯

That effect has a name in this research:

Unanimity break (ally effect) = when the group is no longer unanimous,

pressure to conform drops a lot.

Key point:

The ally doesn’t even have to be super confident or powerful. Just not being totally alone matters.

You’ve now seen:

Group size → more people (up to ~3) = more pressure
Unanimity vs. having an ally → ally = big drop in conformity

Next, I’d like to show how public vs. private answers change things (saying it out loud vs. writing it down secretly).

Want to go there next?

Yes, I'm curious

Great, this part is interesting 🔍

In Asch-style situations, how you respond matters a lot:

Public response = you say your answer out loud in front of everyone.

Private response = you write it down or click it secretly so no one knows what you chose.

Findings:

When answers were public, conformity was much higher.
When answers were private, conformity dropped a lot.

Why?

If no one can see your answer, normative influence (fitting in, avoiding embarrassment) gets much weaker.

Imagine that work meeting again, but this time everyone submits answers anonymously on their laptop.

For you personally, do you think you’d be:

more likely,
less likely,
or
about the same

in sticking with your different answer compared to saying it out loud?

even more likely

That fits perfectly with the data: anonymous = more honest answers ☑

So putting it together:

Public answers → more conformity (strong normative pressure: “What will they think of me?”)
Private answers → less conformity (you can disagree without social cost)

You’ve now seen the big situational levers:

Group size (more people → more pressure, up to a point)
Unanimity vs. ally (one ally drops conformity a lot)
Public vs. private responses (public = more conformity)
Last piece I want to check with you for this lesson:

In your own words:

Why do people in Asch-type situations sometimes give an answer they know is wrong, just because everyone else says it?

You don’t need to be fancy—just a clear, simple explanation.

because they wre raisedf in a group mentality, family, thinks alike, class thinks alike, peers think alike, if yoi disagree you stand out

That’s a strong explanation, Ron 👌

You’re basically saying:

People grow up in groups (family, class, peers) where “thinking alike” is normal.
If you disagree, you stand out.
Standing out can feel risky or uncomfortable, so people sometimes go along even when they know it’s wrong.

Psychology language for what you just described:

That fear of standing out / being the odd one → normative influence.
The pull of “everyone around me thinks this way” → strong group pressure to conform.

Under Asch-style conditions, those forces are extra strong because:

The group is unanimous
The answer is public
You’re alone if you disagree

Put all that together, and many people choose: “I’ll just say what they say.”

From your point of view now, do you feel like you can clearly explain to someone else why people conform in Asch’s experiment (in simple terms)?

If yes, I’ll give you a super short recap and we can call this lesson mastered. If not, tell me what still feels fuzzy.

Yes, I can explain it

Love it. You’ve got this one nailed 🎯

Quick recap in plain language:

Conformity = going along with the group (peers), not because of a direct order, but because of social pressure.
In Asch’s experiment, people often gave wrong answers they knew were wrong because:
they didn’t want to stand out or look stupid (normative influence),
sometimes they doubted themselves when everyone else disagreed (informational influence).
Conformity gets stronger when:
the group is bigger (up to ~3 people),
the group is unanimous,
answers are public.
It gets weaker when:
you have even one ally,
you can answer privately/secretly.
Last reflection before we move on:

Next time you feel pressure to agree with a group, which do you think is more likely to be at work for you personally most of the time — normative influence (fitting in) or informational influence (thinking they might be right)?